

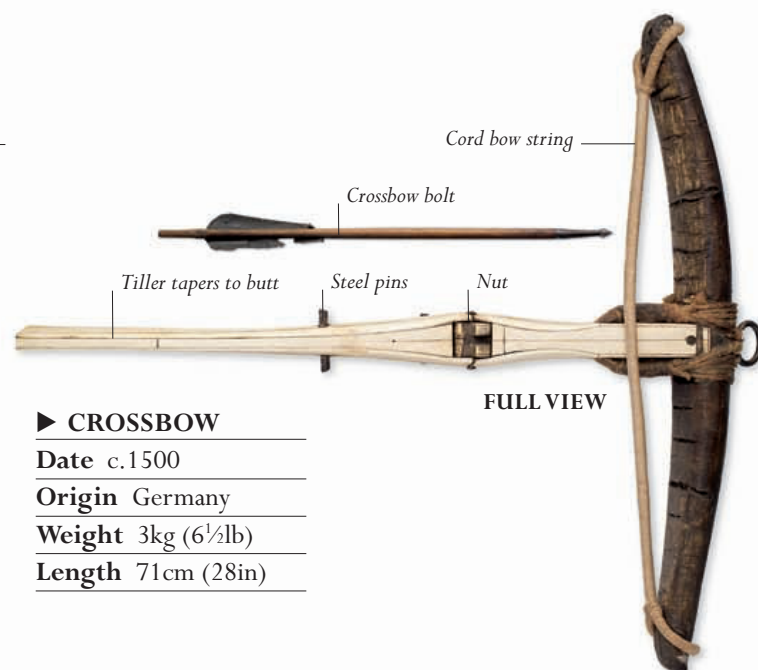
LONG RANGE POWER

CROSSBOW

This typical late medieval European crossbow could shoot a bolt roughly 300m (330 yards). Its composite bow (also known as a lath, or prod), made of layers of wood, sinew, and horn, had far too high a draw weight to be spanned by unaided muscle power – up to around 550kg (1200lb). Crossbowmen used a rack-and-pinion device known as a cranequin (also called a cric or rack) to pull the bowstring back to the nut, where it was hooked, then released it by pressing the long trigger under the crossbow tiller. The crossbowman rested the butt against his shoulder, looking along the tiller and using the tip of the bolt as his sight.

▼ CROSSBOW

This German crossbow, with its handsome bone veneer, would have belonged to a wealthy individual who enjoyed hunting as a leisure pursuit. It was spanned by a small cranequin (below).



► CROSSBOW

Date c.1500

Origin Germany

Weight 3kg (6½lb)

Length 71cm (28in)



▲ CROSSBOW BOLT

Bolts were typically twice as heavy as longbow arrows. The flights were made of wood, paper, or leather, and only two were used, because a third would snag on the nut.

Wooden shaft



▲ CRANEQUIN

The cranequin was introduced in Europe in the late 14th century. One of its advantages was that it could be used on horseback. However, it was an expensive device and was slow to operate, two considerations that made it less suitable for warfare than hunting.